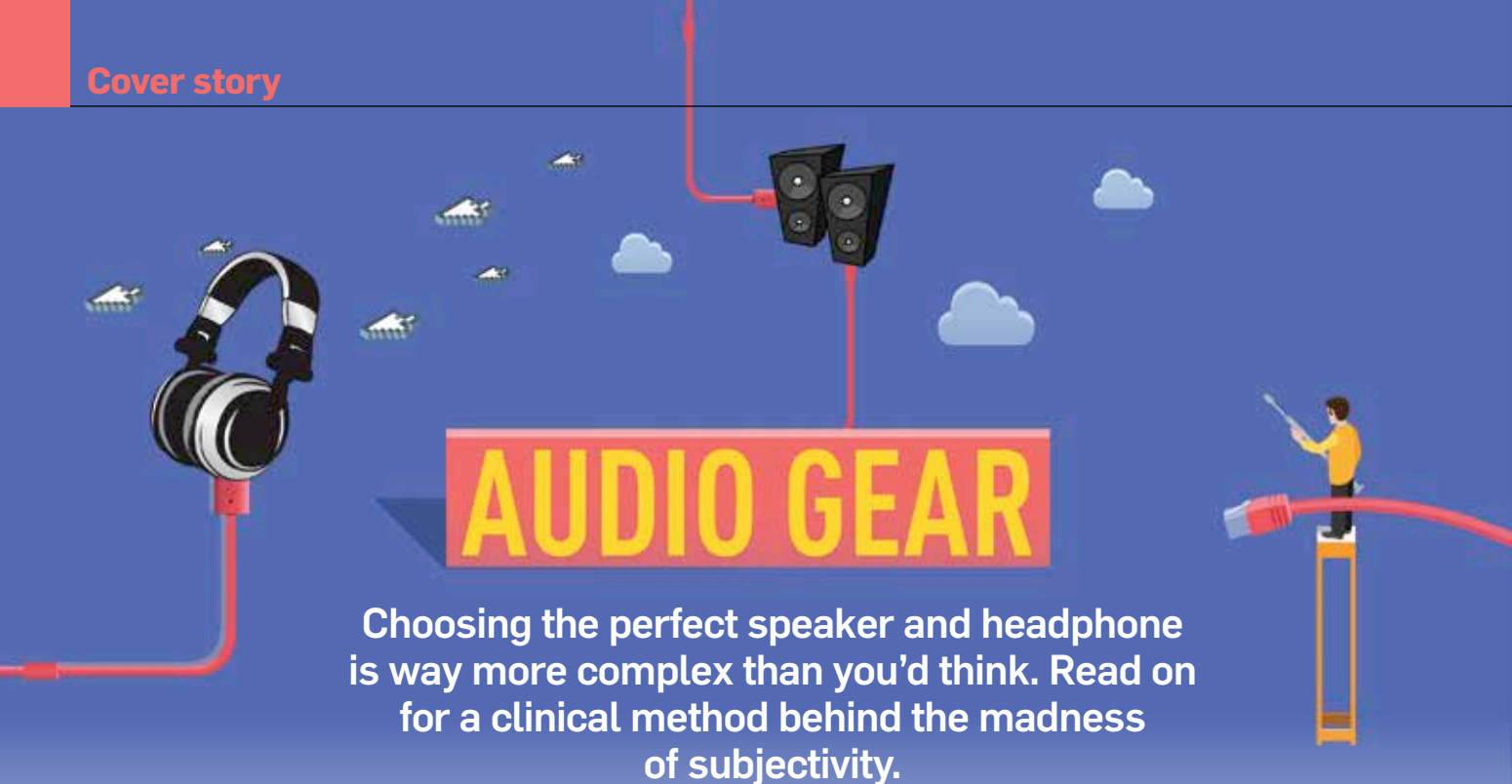




Choosing the perfect speaker and headphone is way more complex than you'd think. Read on for a clinical method behind the madness of subjectivity.

By **Siddharth Parwatay**

While most people don't give it much thought, audio equipment is one of the most diverse, popular and far-reaching product categories out there. From the purely functional earphone to the most opulent receivers and amplifiers – audio products are distinct and often at far ends of the quality spectrum. Most regular folks though are only ever in need of good headphones and PC speakers or at the most portable bluetooth speakers. For this guide, we'll mostly be concentrating primarily on these categories.

Audio is subjective

That old adage of one man's food being another man's poison holds true even in the realm of audio products. Personal preferences overwhelmingly dictate what's considered good or bad. In the simplest of terms, one can think about how some prefer bass while others prefer treble. Strictly speaking, however, that's not the way one should define how good or bad an audio product is. Ideally, a speaker or headphone should be judged by how "true-to-source" the audio actually is. That is, does the speaker reproduce a particular audio track the way the sound engineer mixing it intended it to sound?



Use this to colour your audio all you want, but don't buy speakers predisposed to sounding a certain way

How does one judge that? Is it even possible?

To understand the complexity of the problem we're dealing with, here's a thought experiment of sorts: Think about colours. You know, red, blue and green – those colours that fill the letters in the Google logo. How can you be sure that the way you see the red is the same way the person sitting next to you sees red? You'd really have to get under their skin and into their mind to be able to really experience their experience, right?

Similarly, if we tell you a speaker produces great bass, how are you to know it's indeed great? Your perception of great bass may be completely different from ours. So in the end, does it come down to our word over yours or vice versa? Yes and no.

Minimising this subjectivity is the holy grail of audio testing. And the only way that can be done is by way of empirical testing through machines. It's been an endeavour here at Digit also, but the kind of equipment you need to be able to do